

GEORG BRANDES AND UNIVERSITY PHILOSOPHY

BY

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In a small book, *Georg Brandes og hans Lærere* (Copenhagen 1927), I recently tried to give a sketch of his development, or, I should rather say, of his “variations”, by letting the great critic pass in review before a series of more or less significant literary figures who influenced him at various times. Following a method that common sense and the ever instructive example of Sainte-Beuve both enjoin, I there distinguished between the influence of the teachers of his youth and the later stimuli. When one deals with an author it is of the utmost importance to hold him fast during the period in which his personality comes into being, and not for a moment to let him out of sight, whereas for the later stages, once his mind has become more stationary, one may allow oneself to fix attention chiefly on certain resting places and turning points.

While in that work, where everything depended on a clear survey, I was fortunate enough, for some sections, to be able to refer to premises and documentation in an earlier study (see now my *Litterære Studier*, Copenhagen 1928, pp. 38 ff.), there are other parts where I have had to rely to a greater degree on the reader’s good faith and judgment. This is true above all of the first pages, on Georg Brandes’s relation to the philosophy of his own university, which rested on a thorough study of the large literary remains of the two most influential university professors, Rasmus Nielsen and Hans Brøchner. In what follows I shall try to give a short characterization of these thinkers and authors — not, admittedly, an altogether disinterested portrait, for it has throughout been made with Georg Brandes’s writings in mind, and with the greatest attention to the side they turn towards him.

I.

Rasmus Nielsen was, at the time Brandes came to the university, in his fullest strength. He had just then freed himself from his earlier almost slavish dependence

on Søren Kierkegaard's thoughts, and at the same time as his philosophy of religion began to take on a distinctive form, he sought to reform metaphysics by drawing on the exact sciences.

The kind of thinking he chiefly cultivated was the concordat. He wanted to unite the most heterogeneous phenomena; and the formula for the union was that *precisely because*, for example (and first and foremost), faith and knowledge are absolutely heterogeneous, they can thrive in the same consciousness. If his dialectic was not profound, it has nonetheless sharpened problems to a high degree. Instead of levelling and mediating he always sought out new disagreements and exaggerated the oppositions to the point of absurdity. In this he followed in the footsteps of his oldest master, since Hegel's method is built on the principle of opposition; but he has his strength precisely where Hegel has his weakness, in that Hegel lays more weight on showing how the one category is intimated in the other than on showing that the one is self-contradictory unless the other is added.

But he solved the problems only by cutting the knot. Faith and knowledge are absolutely heterogeneous, to begin with. Next, will and the faculty of knowledge, their organs, are absolutely heterogeneous. Then, finally, a distinction is drawn between theoretical and practical knowledge, and even here the same heterogeneity is found! Rasmus Nielsen was under influence from the most various quarters: from Martensen he went over to Søren Kierkegaard, and Søren Kierkegaard's and Grundtvig's thoughts he later sought to bring under one hat. But beside this Christian speculation there flourished in him a radical interest in natural science.

A feeling for the special sciences was something surprising in Danish philosophy, so soon after the nature-less thinking of Martensen and Kierkegaard had entirely occupied people's minds. Rasmus Nielsen held the Hegelian speculation to have failed, because its concepts were not sufficiently controlled by the individual scientific disciplines. He wanted a new encyclopaedia of the sciences to replace the Hegelian one, which still seemed to him burdened with theology and scholasticism. From the end of the fifties he, who until then had thought only about religious questions, [147] worked as best he could at mathematics, physics, chemistry and biology. After some less successful attempts¹ he finally got well under way, and his series *Forelæsninger over filosofisk Propædeutik* (three volumes from the beginning of the sixties),

¹*Philosophisk Propædeutik i Grundtræk* (1857), *Philosophie og Mathematik* (the same year), *Mathematik og Dialektik* (1859), *Om Begrebet Nøiagtighed* (1860), *Hr. Professor Steens "Afregning"* (the same year).

Naturphilosophie (1873) and *Almindelig Videnskabslære* (1880) show an ever more intimate working of the principles and results of the special sciences into philosophy.

Georg Brandes did not in his young days take much interest in natural inquiry and the exact sciences, and he could hardly be captivated by Rasmus Nielsen because of his merits in that direction. But it no doubt had an awakening effect on him to see all the sciences contribute to the building of a philosophical system, as opposed to the ambiguous “immanent” logic of Hegel and Brøchner. And later, when he met positivist philosophy on his way, he was in certain respects prepared.

By his many-sidedness and his ability to set up oppositions, Rasmus Nielsen came to mean a great deal to many as an introducer to the problems of philosophy. Georg Brandes himself speaks of him as an awakener, with recognition and praise. He had, moreover, a spirited written and above all spoken delivery: people would have it that he was the most eloquent man in Denmark.

He won Brandes by his personality. He possessed a liveliness of mind which seems to have recalled Brandes’s own. He was in constant development; and if he was not very original, he took up in the course of time the thoughts of a series of significant minds in an independent way. There was in him an eternal appetite for every intellectual phenomenon, from religious to mathematical problems; the miracles of the New Testament, Darwinism and the defence question set him vibrating with equal force. For anyone with an eye for the characteristic, he also seems in his outward appearance to have offered something of interest, as one can read in Brandes’s obituary.

In another respect Georg Brandes must have felt drawn to him as to a kindred nature. Rasmus Nielsen was a considerable literary talent, with even a certain journalistic bent. From his first appearance he had shown an unerring eye for what was topical and could make an impression. His philosophy came into being by taking up [148] other men’s thoughts at the right time. The theory of the relation between faith and knowledge is “freely after” Søren Kierkegaard. If this reworking has little philosophical value, it has on the other hand some literary value. The slogan of the absolute heterogeneity of faith and knowledge was an excellent programme for an intellectual movement in the 1860s, a brilliant popularization of Kierkegaard’s ideas, which in their genuine form were not exactly suited to catch on among the bourgeoisie. And it was an able political feat to bring the followers of Kierkegaard and of Grundtvig closer to one another.¹ It was also useful to work at removing religious suspicion

¹Compare Frederik Jungersen: *Dansk Protestantisme ved S. Kjerkegaard, N. F. S. Grundtvig og R.*

from scientific research. By his struggle of many years to tear theology down and, on the other hand, to preserve Protestant Christianity and the Church, he is remarkable, rather as a leader of the people than as a critical thinker.

If one wants to see to what degree he was an advocate in his thinking, one should read some of his rather numerous polemical writings. Here his standpoint in the philosophy of religion changes constantly with his development and with the various opponents he faces. Nowhere does the tough peasant nature show itself better than in his stubborn and not wholly unfruitful philosophical polemic. What tone is to be struck, how expansively one is to proceed, all depends on the opponent he has to deal with. Bishop Martensen he is always ready to give full measure, up to a hundred and fifty pages; Provost Zeuthen gets less at once; Brøchner, his colleague in the very narrowest sense, whose very bitter attack cannot be left unanswered, is dispatched in a good three sheets; Georg Brandes and A. C. Larsen, who are only young graduates, receive no answer at all.

He is no critical talent; the detailed logical discussion of the argument he avoids, and keeps to certain points in the opponent that can bring public opinion over to his side: in Martensen the theological universal monarchy is made ridiculous, in Brøchner the incomprehensible terminology; on Martensen the suspicion is cast that he wants to put an end to free inquiry, Brøchner is accused of personal enmity and hatred of [149] Christianity. Nothing prevents him from going round the main issue; for example, “the absolute heterogeneity” is passed over in the piece against Brøchner.

Rasmus Nielsen was, finally, something of a stylist. His manner of writing is just as little original as his thinking. It descends directly from that of Kierkegaard’s philosophical writings: the same overloading with climaxes, repetitions, parallels, antitheses, puns, the whole barbaric ornament. But he gradually succeeded in transforming the master’s passionate and individual delivery into a broad, vivid art of persuasion. Often he abuses the figure of antithesis to the point of disgust; and he plays a game with the anaphoric sentence that it takes strong nerves not to be irritated by. In *Om den gode Villie* he lets each of five sections, over two pages, begin with the question: “But how is the dualism to be overcome?”¹. It cannot be denied that his manner of expression gains in pedagogy what it loses in taste. Whatever he touches comes alive. He knows how to present the most abstruse *metaphysica* in a stimulating way and with a kind of intelligibility, in so far as what is obscurely thought can ever

Nielsen, Copenhagen 1873.

¹In part slightly varied; see the work cited, pp. 73 ff.

become what is clearly said. In this he is quite different from Brøchner, who smothers all life in his logical-terminological armour, and whose intricate sentence structure seems to have no other principle than to separate what naturally belongs together for the understanding.

Rasmus Nielsen shuns no means of holding the attention captive: popular sayings, bold allusions, familiar quotations, coarse images in abundance. He even undertakes to renew the technical terms; and when he uses the forbidding foreign words, he often personifies them a little, which is undeniably more helpful to intuitive understanding than to the logical process. On the whole he likes to make concepts into persons or tangible things: "The theology of Scripture, so youthfully fresh, so trusting, so proud of the Bible in its Paradise — how has it, after the Fall through the logical-physical, gradually been weakened, bowed, bleached, humbled!"². He is fond of exclamations, dialogisms and outright dialogues, not only between A and B and Caius, but also, for example, between Theology and the Congregation:

"What have you done", the Congregation asks Theology, sinful by its Fall, "with my Christmas Gospel?" Alas, dear Congregation, do not be angry; criticism has unfortunately torn the Christmas Gospel clean to pieces. But do not lose heart! remember that it is knowledge that is to help faith; remember what Bishop Martensen says with Anselm: "I do not venture, O Lord, to fathom thy depths;" but I believe that knowledge is to help faith. Do not weep; the Gospel that criticism has torn to pieces, apologetics can, after all, put together again ...

[150]

You look so darkly at me. What can I do about science being objective? Who would have thought, too, that the historical facts in the Christmas Gospel were so strangely brittle, the natural elements just as brittle as the supernatural ...¹

When his wit does not run away with him too much, he also knows how to build up a book simply and in a way all can understand; this is especially the case with his popular writings after 1870, but also with earlier works. It holds, for example, already of *En undersøgende Anmeldelse* (1849) and of his most forceful polemic, the previously cited *Om den gode Villie* (1867), which simply and clearly establishes the impossibility of theology's supremacy over the other sciences by showing first history's, then the natural sciences', and finally philosophy's untenable position in such a union. The

²The work cited, pp. 48 f.

¹Ib. p. 49.

double work *Religionsphilosophie* (1869) — *Naturphilosophie* (1873) is also cleverly planned, *Grundideernes Logik* (1864–66), on the other hand, confused.

In keeping with this, Georg Brandes is seen in his small reviews from the end of the sixties to take pleasure in Rasmus Nielsen as an author. In the review of *Om den gode Villie* he permits himself small remarks on the literary character of the work: “a broad and racy, a mocking and biting little book, written with an overflowing delight in production and full of good ideas. Its merriment has nonetheless in places a more Dutch than Danish character”², “the excellently witty little piece that ends with the words ...”³. Brandes’s whole account of Rasmus Nielsen’s relation to Martensen and theology belongs in the same place.

When Brandes’s former opponent, Rasmus Nielsen’s apostate disciple P. S. V. Heegaard, wrote a treatise against the doctrine of his once idolized master, Brandes had the triumph of being able to take Heegaard to task for his lack of recognition of “his so highly gifted teacher” and to weave in some laudatory characterizations: “he has the luxuriantly fertile mind, the inspired eye, the rare originality, which are just [151] as essential faculties in a thinker as a strictly scientific training of thought and a keen, reliable understanding”¹.

It is hardly unwarranted to find some dependence on Rasmus Nielsen’s style in these reviews and in the pamphlet *Dualismen i vor nyeste Filosofi*. One does not arrive, by the mere study of Taine and with Gabriel Sibbern’s assistance², at writing a modern prose that all can understand. At the least, Georg Brandes’s inclination towards dialogue in these works smacks just as much of Rasmus Nielsen as of Taine: “[it was] good policy on the part of the philosophical champion to proceed by attack and answer Bishop Martensen’s polite ‘Good day’ with a terrible ‘Axe-handle’”³. “Look at *Grundideernes Logik*, says the author [i.e. Heegaard]: the best thing would be for Professor Nielsen, who is after all unable to finish building it, to let it stand at once as an ‘interesting ruin’, that is, as a kind of Marble Church. ‘Marble Church yourself’, answers Professor Nielsen, calmly pointing to the first part of the far-famed *Indledning til den rationelle Etik*”⁴ (in this work Heegaard, as is well known, was still at the Nielsenian stage, and it was notoriously never continued). Here there are jokes

²Georg Brandes, *Samlede Skrifter* XIII p. 85.

³Ib. 87.

¹Ib. p. 108.

²See my *Litterære Studier* (Copenhagen 1928), pp. 45 f.

³G. B. *Saml. Skr.* XIII p. 91.

⁴Ib. p. 107.

in an unmistakably Nielsenian manner: “Professor Nielsen has indeed one man on guard, but he weeps — with one eye and laughs with the other; his right hand knows not what the left is doing. He moves forward on two heterogeneous legs, a leg of flesh and a wooden leg, on two absolutely split legs, cleft like one of Uffe’s Saxons. His head is a Janus head: with one mouth he proclaims the higher fulfilment of the law of nature through the miracle; with his other throat he gives cultural consciousness the honour and sings a well-meant hymn of praise to David Strauss”⁵.

How deep the impression of Rasmus Nielsen goes is seen clearly, finally, from the obituary Brandes wrote of him⁶ (1884). Here he gives him quite certainly all he deserved as a personality, as a thinker a little more, and brings out finely and surely his overlooked merits as a writer.

As we have seen, then, he stood in some debt of gratitude to his old professor of the *filosofikum*. He was reckoned by contemporaries from every camp, with good [152] reason, as one of Rasmus Nielsen’s most dangerous enemies. This earned him civilities from Nielsen’s older opponents and drew curses upon him from his followers. Thus he is mentioned with honour in Martensen’s *Om Tro og Viden* (1867) — whose diction, like that of almost every contribution to this famous controversy, is a little infected by Rasmus Nielsen’s — as the “gifted author” of whom one “can only wish that he may not too early get beyond the Platonic *θαυμάζειν* (wonder) as the beginning of philosophy”¹. Conversely, Brandes gets a lecture and a scolding in the aforementioned book by Fr. Jungersen, *Dansk Protestantisme*, where the pamphlet on *Dualismen* is called “an extraordinarily frivolous criticism”². The many times Brandes himself spoke of Rasmus Nielsen, in writings or in interviews, it was always with high regard, at times almost with tenderness. If one studies the relation at close range, one sees that more than one thread leads from the great Voltairean critic back to the Kierkegaardian sophist.

II.

The relation to *Hans Brøchner* is far simpler and more transparent. The man to whom Georg Brandes dedicated his principal work was his real, strict educator; he

⁵Ib. p. 91 — as to the substance of the matter there is nothing exaggerated: those who today hold that Jesus never existed as a historical and actual person can without risk put Rasmus Nielsen on the list of those who think as they do.

⁶*Saml. Skr.* II pp. 419 ff.

¹The work cited, p. 8.

²The work cited, pp. 210 f.

plays a role in his life similar to that of Vacherot in Taine's, and, like Vacherot, was no uncritical spectator of his pupil's rapid development.³ In his *Levned* Brandes has piously recorded the day of his first visit to the beloved teacher: "it was the 2nd of September 1861", and has given an account in every detail of their intellectual companionship. Here I add only what a commentator might further have to recall.

[153] Brøchner was a quiet, introverted thinker and scholar, who at that time had not yet published his most important works. But he had them finished in his head and could later publish them in definitive form in a surprisingly short time. Through lectures and private conversation their content was known to Brandes long before they appeared in print.

In a private letter to Chr. K. F. Molbech Brøchner expressed the wish to leave behind two works: one that could show he had known something, one that could testify that he had understood how to think.

The first he has displayed in his works on the history of philosophy, where on the one hand — with the assurance of an old general-staff officer — he skeletonizes the most representative metaphysical edifices from Greek philosophy in its tragic age down to Hegel, and on the other hand reads speculatively the work of the world spirit in the laws which he believes determine the development of thought, and which thinkers unconsciously follow. A literary historian naturally has much to object to in these works of learning because of their stiff-necked deductive procedure — Brøchner had a predilection for writings in the form of handbooks and all-embracing systems, and an unparalleled contempt for the connection between philosophy and the other sciences, which makes parts of his writings, for example the treatment of French materialism in the eighteenth century, altogether misleading; and his inclination to establish speculative connections weakens the significance of the sections where he was best grounded, philologically too, as in the account of the philosophy of the Greeks.¹ But his historical works, notably the handbook in two volumes (1873–74),

³In *Tilskueren* for February 1912, p. 213, Dr. Poul Levin published Brøchner's assessment of the dissertation Brandes submitted for the doctorate, which I here take the liberty of reprinting: "It seems to me that Cand. Brandes's dissertation, judged from a purely philosophical point of view, has two not inconsiderable shortcomings. The treatment of the problems it raises is somewhat aphoristic, and in showing Taine's relation to his historical presuppositions in the field of philosophy there is an incompleteness, which means that it does not become sufficiently evident to what striking degree he lacks originality, depth and consistency as a philosopher. But these shortcomings of the dissertation are no doubt amply outweighed by its great merits: by its rich content, which testifies to a comprehensive and well-assimilated wealth of knowledge in the author, by the keen, fine and spiritedly individualized understanding of its subject, and by the life and freshness of the presentation. I therefore have no doubt that the dissertation ought to be accepted."

¹His insight into medieval thought has benefited others only through the commentary to Chr. K. F.

still command respect by their precision and thoroughness.

His capacity for independent thought he has proved in the two books that give his own philosophy: *Problemet om Tro og Viden* (1868) and *Om det Religiøse i dets Enhed med det Humane* (1869).

He begins — not without a sense of the topical — with a criticism of contemporary Danish philosophy's and theology's attempts to solve the question of faith versus knowledge. He rejects the theological philosophy of faith, represented by Martensen, which wants to build up a supra-logical science of things that it itself admits cannot be known. He rejects further, with reverence and admiration, Søren Kierkegaard, who breaks the connection between the personality and universally valid knowledge by [154] defining faith as "the objective uncertainty held fast in the appropriation of the most passionate inwardness", and who, by denying the natural side of man, sets an insoluble disharmony in the personality and in existence. He rejects, finally, Rasmus Nielsen's doctrine of absolute heterogeneity, as a sham solution, an anarchy of irreconcilable contradictions.

If one wants to explain the relation between faith and knowledge, one must, according to Brøchner, take one's point of departure in one of these spheres. And he chooses — like Hegel — knowledge, because only knowledge can give an independent view of existence. Faith could not stand alone, but would have to lean on knowledge in the face of such a task.

He now builds up a whole monistic and idealistic metaphysics. He rejects once and for all the atomistic way of looking at things and will operate only with totalities. The whole of existence is an absolute totality, and within it the individual is in turn a relative totality, which has its task to fulfil within the absolute.

The principle of existence is ideal. The real is a transitional stage in the development of the Idea; the Idea is both the ground of the totality and its end. Brøchner dissolves all dualisms: knowledge and will are not heterogeneous, the will has a knowledge as its content, and it develops "from the first immediate, single determination by impulse" through reflection "to a determination by consciously formed principles, maxims, from which the unity of a view of life can then emerge"¹. Nor is there any difference of quality between theoretical and practical knowledge. The difference is placed in this, that practical knowledge is personal, theoretical knowledge impersonal — but "the act of knowing, which is subject to the norm of the idea of truth, has in

Molbech's translation of Dante (1851–62), for which he supplied the philosophical material.

¹*Om det Religiøse* pp. 18 f.

that norm an 'ought', in relation to which there is consciousness of responsibility"².

Brøchner's philosophy of religion is determined by these basic concepts. The religious relation is seen as the human spirit's "absolute relation to the Absolute", i.e. its undivided and unconditional devotion to and subordination under the eternal and unchanging ground-force of existence. Both knowledge and will must take part. Knowledge is continued in a postulate: faith. There is in all lower and higher knowledge a moment of faith, namely trust in the unity and lawfulness of existence, and a moment of devotion: "In all true knowledge there is a purification of thought, a [155] giving up of individual prejudice, opinion and bias, in a word: of the selfishness of thought; there is in it a self-surrender to the absolute power of truth"¹. The faith that is present in knowledge is rational, and must therefore reject everything that conflicts with the principle of sufficient reason and of necessity, for example the miracle. The will is continued in self-surrender, as the individual becomes conscious of itself "as an organic member of the totality of existence" and "chooses to act accordingly". The moment of faith shows itself in the ethical, which is "the expression of the true, essential willing and acting"; it comes forward "in every ethical decision in which the individual resolves on action despite the incompleteness of knowledge and the uncertainty of its realization, of the outcome"². The moment of devotion is seen in this, that the principle of the ethical is love.

The strife that constantly rages between representatives of knowledge and of faith in its positive form is therefore not due to an opposition of principle: the cause must lie in the finitude of the human spirit's conditions. If we disregard everything finite in the positive religions, we find that the most important, or the one thing needful, in them is the demand for subordination, self-surrender, which is thus also found in knowledge. Faith and knowledge, then, do not conflict: there remains "no doubt something like a gap between faith and knowledge, but a gap that must be able to be traversed by knowledge"³. Brøchner believed he could observe in the history of religions a constant progress towards a more purified religiosity. The highest standpoint is the religion of humanity, which does not need to be created but only to be pointed out, for the religious is already present, "if often unclearly and half-consciously", in the humane consciousness of our time.

In connection with his religious view Brøchner treats the ethical problems in a

²Ib. p. 15.

¹Ib. pp. 50 f.

²Ib. p. 55.

³Ib. p. 51.

very speculative spirit. Free will is seen in man's capacity to assert himself, according to his infinite determination of essence, over against the external and accidental. Evil is a disturbance in "the normal relation between man's being as a relative totality and as a member of the universal totality, and between the natural and the spiritual side in it." The will is evil when it is self-will and sets itself up against the demand of the Absolute. Striking is the optimism of this ethical view: wide possibilities are left open for repentance and reconciliation, and distrust is expressed of the evil will's capacity to endure. Evil is rather an accident, which moreover has the greatest probability of correcting itself. The will to evil has a natural tendency to turn round into the good; it borrows its strength from the Absolute¹, and so must fight against the ground of its [156] own being and in the end destroy itself.

When all is said and done, his view is a religious optimism. Values are preserved; nothing essential is lost. He denies, for example, personal immortality, but holds that the individual spirit, at the destruction of the organism, is taken up "as a moment in the life of the Eternal"; it is transformed into "a moment in God's knowledge of himself in his eternal kingdom of spirit"². Existence is a cosmos.

Brøchner reproached the Hegelian philosophy for not letting reality come sufficiently into its own. The same can, however, be said of his own system. It is spiritualistic and transcendent like Hegel's. It is without relation to the special sciences, and in that respect far less modern than Rasmus Nielsen's. With all its consistency and firmness it is extremely exclusive, completely closed on all sides. It is hard to know what advantage philosophy could draw in the future from natural inquiry and exact science, although Brøchner himself pointed the philosophers of the future to this field of work in his writings on the history of philosophy. The method, too, is the old "immanent" development of concepts, however much Brøchner himself inveighed against it³.

The above meagre account of Brøchner's religious free thought — a last shoot on the stem of romantic philosophy, the speculative testament of an epigone firm in his principles — may serve as a background to, and to complete, the interesting account in Brandes's *Levnede* of how he became a freethinker, and may be compared with the summary presentation in my aforementioned study *Georg Brandes og hans Lærere*, pp. 6 ff. It goes without saying that the intimate influence from master to pupil in the

¹Compare Georg Brandes's *Æsthetiske Studier* p. 116: "the power of the bad is the strength it has sucked from the good."

²*Om det Religiøse* p. 189.

³See his *Bidrag til Opfattelsen af Filosofiens historiske Udvikling* (1869) pp. 265 f.

time before Brøchner began his real, central authorship, and before Brandes published anything at all, is a thing that cannot be made the object of objective investigation and matter-of-fact discussion.

But one sees at least from Brandes's own words and from Brøchner's printed writings what sort of education the future critic of naturalism received. His youthful thinking was schooled in an abstract and idealistic philosophy of concepts. And the [157] thinkers to whom Brøchner introduced him were of the same kind. But regardless of everything that Brandes later let drop as at bottom incompatible with his nature, there are features in Brøchner's philosophy that were bound to win his full assent. It is, as has been shown, strictly monistic, and by its unconditional holding fast to one principle it counteracted all the temptations to a dualistic view of life, of which the age had plenty. Next, it is markedly intellectualist. It asserts the primacy of knowledge in the human spirit, and chooses knowledge to give the key to the riddles of existence. Finally, it is avowedly freethinking. Brøchner was a stubborn champion of the unlimited rights of "free thought" and was hated as an enemy of Christianity, an accusation that he rejects with great force and dignity in his *Svar til Professor R. Nielsen* (1868). His opinion of Christianity can be seen from his view of positive religions in general; moreover, his book *Om det Religiøse* contains here and there sharp criticism of the chief Christian conceptions: the miracle, creation, immortality, and of the tendency of Christian doctrine to deny the natural — he held to the correctness of Kierkegaard's picture of Christianity against Martensen's. As a young man he had had to suffer a refusal from the theological degree examination for his openly avowed view of the miracles as mythical. He was one of those who had introduced Strauss¹ and studied Feuerbach, a thinker who has meant much for the development of the religious standpoint to which he held unshakably.

The writings of Georg Brandes in which one would most naturally look for special and tangible influences from Brøchner are *Den franske Æstetik i vore Dage*, his most academic work, and *Emigrantlitteraturen*, his freethinker's manifesto. But what is to be found here is microscopic.

The dissertation, in which he so to speak lays out his younger teacher's doctrines before his older teacher, is certainly a clean piece of pupil's work, which follows the master's method of preparing a philosophical system: give its presuppositions and pass judgment (on which, as will be seen from the note above, p. 152, the two parties were nevertheless not agreed). But in the details one finds only odds and ends.

¹*Den christelige Troeslære ... Oversat af H. Brøchner, Cand. phil.* 2 vols. 1842–43.

The most important passage is p. 241, where I find influence from Brøchner's *Om det Religiøse*: "Taine has started from Spinoza's standpoint, that man is a part of the whole and not 'a state within the state'; but he has gone so far as to conclude that [158] man cannot be a citizen of this state either, is only a product without personality, without freedom and without real rights. He thus comes to ignore self-consciousness for the good reason that he cannot explain it, since he lacks any concept of *man as a relative totality* and understands nature from the idea of mechanism instead of from that of organism."

In the first three volumes of *Hovedstrømningerne*, too, Brandes wanted to continue Brøchner's work; this was clear to contemporaries, and his opponents hoped to hit the master when they shot at the disciple. *Emigrantlitteraturen*¹ is dedicated to Brøchner "with gratitude and friendship". *Den romantiske Skole i Tyskland* has the following afterword, not reprinted later:

Dear Professor,

It goes without saying that this volume, just as much as the preceding one, is dedicated to you. With my university lectures as its basis it contains a good deal that could not find room, or would not have been in its place, in the spoken lecture. It has been my hope while working it out that men such as you would find pleasure in this book. For me a book is an act. You will judge it as such.

You know Heine's words, Professor: "Sonderbar! und immer ist es die Religion, und immer die Moral, und immer der Patriotismus, womit alle schlechten Subjecte ihre Angriffe beschönigen! sie greifen uns an, nicht aus schäbigen Privatinteressen, nicht aus Schriftstellerneid, nicht aus angeborenem Knechtsinn, sondern um den lieben Gott, um die guten Sitten und das Vaterland zu retten." — Happily, for me a whole bundle of anonymous articles and pamphlets is outweighed by one word from you.

Copenhagen, April 1873.

Yours

G. B.

But although *Hovedstrømningerne* in its original design is a continuation of Brøchner's polemic with theologians and dualists — the very title and the often recurring

¹On whose academic character and whole position I may refer to my *Litterære Studier*, pp. 80 ff.

slogan “free thought” come from him — I do not believe it will be possible to demonstrate Brøchnerian influences in it in detail. It is only in the sixth volume, the book on *det unge Tyskland*, that the already ageing Brandes ties the thread to his Hegelian youth and describes the Young Hegelian struggle for freedom of thought and against [159] clericalism. Here he puts in his teacher’s Left-Hegelian interpretation of Hegel’s metaphysics¹.

There is only a quite small group of Brandes’s writings in which one can say that the influence from Brøchner goes more into particulars: the polemical works from the years on either side of 1870. Moreover, it is possible that the influence was mutual; at any rate Brøchner’s oldest occasional piece, a contribution to the baptismal controversy at the beginning of the forties, stands far behind those with which he contributed to the dispute over faith and knowledge. It was Georg Brandes himself who forced the pen into his hand² and got him first to criticize his contemporaries’ views, and then to develop his own; after that the rest followed of itself.

In *Dualismen i vor nyeste Filosofi* (1866), which is older than Brøchner’s contributions to the controversy, one should accordingly not expect formal influence, but the line of thought is quite certainly inspired through and through by Brøchner’s; it also agrees excellently with Brøchner’s own deductions two years later in *Problemet om Tro og Viden*. First there is an account of everything tempting in Rasmus Nielsen’s philosophy: suspicion is even cast on the possible opponent: “the individual who appears not for the sake of the cause, but in order to bring his own little self into the foreground by means of the great cause”³. But then “the medal is turned”, and the explosives are thrown down with all the greater force. And after confidence in the system has been shaken, it is proved with strict logic both that the premises of the thesis put forward do not agree with the conclusion, and that the conclusion is in itself a self-contradiction. Next it is shown that the auxiliary concept “the anti-rational” is a hopelessly obscurantist notion. Finally, the ruinous consequences of the asserted dualism throughout its originator’s system are demonstrated, and the failed attempts at soldering are laid bare, until the system is at last condemned in its pitifulness as a piece of failed eclecticism.

The basic thoughts are the following. 1° — Propositions of faith and propositions of knowledge, as Rasmus Nielsen sets them up, are not absolutely heterogeneous.

¹Compare again *Georg Brandes og hans Lærere*, pp. 13 ff.

²See Brandes’s *Levnede I* p. 177.

³The work cited, p. 11.

Propositions such as “The world was created in six days” — “The world was not created in six days” are merely conflicting, incompatible. But even if faith and knowledge really were heterogeneous, it would still not help, since heterogeneity is only another expression for incompatibility. And it would presuppose a split both in consciousness [160] and in existence. 2° — Postulates of faith can be criticized by knowledge: “whoever — be it as believer or as knower — assumes anything whatever about the origin of the earth has an assumption that geology can correct”¹. 3° — The “anti-rational”, Rasmus Nielsen’s unparalleled discovery, falls entirely outside scientific discussion, since it cannot be expressed in rational concepts or even in language.

Religion is not criticized in the little work. One remark leaves open the possibility of a religion without miracles: “If ‘religion presupposes a revelation and revelation a miracle, but science denies the miracle and rejects revelation’ ... then the form of the religious that can be reconciled with science can only be one that is without miracles and without revelation”².

Forklaring og Forsvar, En Antikritik (1872) is, conversely, influenced in form, but hardly in content, by Brøchner’s intervening polemical writings, notably by *Et Svar til Professor R. Nielsen*. Brandes admired in the highest degree Brøchner’s ability as a polemicist. In his essay on the beloved teacher from 1886 he writes of it:

His war of attack on the theologians, or on Nielsen’s masked-theological philosophy, was a model of superior tactics. He would usually first develop with the greatest precision the view he meant to dispute, then set out point by point the proofs of its untenability, then adduce everything that could conceivably be urged from the opponent’s side against these proofs, and explain why this supposed defence would mean nothing; then he proved that no defence other than the one adduced could be made at all.

When this was done, he dissolved the opponent’s conceptual structure, made him concessions, supposed *per impossibile* that one of the overthrown main points was a firm fortress, and showed that even so the most decisive determinations of concept contained contradiction upon contradiction. Step by step he went round his opponent’s doctrinal edifice, and, well acquainted with his manner of fighting, he stopped every hole through which he might try to escape, until he had him safely caught. Then he would usually end by enumerating the main points in all the contradictions shown, and closed at last the criticism, held in

¹Ib. p. 31.

²Ib. p. 60. Cf. the passage on Parker, ib. pp. 73 f.

the most serious tone, with an irony that one could in all truth, and without abuse of the word, call terrible.³

[161] Brandes's own tactics in the five short chapters of his *Forklaring* of 1872 are not much different from those he has described here. It is especially clear that he imitates Brøchner every time he passes from the defensive to the offensive. He first meets the numerous attacks in the press. By deftly chosen quotations the opponents are made to contradict themselves every time they put forward a claim; and he is not afraid to use his victory in such a way that he grants the opponent to be right in what has just been proved to be wrong, in order then to show that it does not help him anyway:

I have said: That a literature lives in our day is shown by its putting problems up for debate. I have said, which *Dagbladet* passes over without further ado: in our day; I have not claimed that in the time of Homer or Hesiod the proof of a literature's life lay in its discussion of problems. I have just as little spoken of Shakespeare's age. But when my reviewer in *Dagbladet* at last asks what problems *Lear* or *Macbeth* puts up for debate, I take the liberty, without further ado, of referring him, as a beginner in aesthetic study, to the first handbook on Shakespeare that comes to hand, for example Ulrici's or Gervinus's. There he will find an answer ...¹

The war is carried into the enemy's own country. Rudolph Schmidt had reproached Georg Brandes for his imitations, in content and language, of French literature:

What harm is there in that? When one walks in the sun, one gets sunburnt. But suppose now those accusations came from a man of letters who has followed his teacher through thick and thin as a lackey follows his master, whose opinion is the opinion Mr. N. holds today, whose opinion was the one Mr. N. held yesterday, and whose opinion will be the one Mr. N. will hold tomorrow! He forgets, then, to say that while I at least have breathed the free air of Europe, he has breathed only his teacher's breath.²

But at the end of each chapter he rises from the easily won bickering to general principles. This holds especially of the polemic against "44", a pseudonym of Bishop

³*Saml. Skr.* II pp. 429 f.

¹The work cited, p. 20.

²*Ib.* pp. 39 f. — R. Schmidt wrote under the signature "k"; Brandes, as one sees, breaks the pseudonymity and alludes to his faithful service as squire to "N.", i.e. Rasmus Nielsen.

Monrad. Finally he ends, like Brøchner in his reply to Rasmus Nielsen, with a dignified emphasis on the fact that his conviction is firm and dearly bought, and therefore not easily overturned by attacks.

The above observations and reflections are, admittedly, only small matters. But [162] when they concern an authorship whose place in Danish literary history will quite certainly always be very prominent, they are not superfluous. It is always worth the trouble to remember the names of the distinctive personalities who introduced the young Georg Brandes to the problems of intellectual life, and to keep them in mind when reading his earliest writings.